

## Interview Transcript - Ameera

(0:00 - 2:23)

Interviewer: So, can you tell me about a time you worked closely with a colleague who had a language barrier? What was like that day to day?

Interviewee: Okay, so that was for my Comp 1100 class, Intro to Software Innovation. So we were grouped into teams of five and then we're supposed to make a software solution out of a problem, let's say for students mostly. And in my team, out of five, three of them were like of a different nationality.

Interviewee: So there obviously was like some language barrier over there. All three of them, yeah.

Interviewer: Okay, so has miscommunication with them ever caused a real problem, like let's say a mistake, a missed deadline or confusion in a task? Could you describe it?

Interviewee: I feel like the course itself has like a lot of check-ins, so it didn't get that bad.

Interviewee: But miscommunications has happened because like my colleague weren't as fluent in English. So there's this time where my partner and I like my other Indonesian friend. So since we had more experience using this app called GitHub, the two of us were gonna teach the other three, right? Because like my colleague were Chinese and like GitHub is like not available in China.

Interviewee: So one of them couldn't make it. We understand that he couldn't make it. So it's like we're doing the two offline and the other guy like we opened Discord.

Interviewee: But the miscommunication happened because he felt like he was gonna have to be there. So he's like, no, I can't go there. We're like, we know.

Interviewee: We're just saying like, we're out here online. If you can't join, just join. If you can't, we're gonna teach you like on another time.

Interviewee: And I think it caused like a bit of frustration because he was out, like he had some business to do. He was busy as well. So like, yeah.

(2:25 - 3:57)

Interviewer: Okay, so could you tell me what tools you use to better communicate with each other?

Interviewee: But tools, I think at one point we did use Google Translate. But instead of tools, I'd much rather imagine them speaking in English, but in simpler terms. So that not only will help their English, but will also help us communicate because the course required us to just speak like in English.

Interviewee: But if all hell broke loose that one time, I still remember talking in my very broken Chinese. And I think they kind of got it. But I feel like the most work done was us talking in simpler terms or like when we chat, we're not using complete slang.

Interviewer: Yeah. So besides slang, could you tell me about some ways you had to adjust the way you speak so they understand?

Interviewee: Um, how I adjust the way? I would say speaking more slowly, definitely. And enunciating my words a little more.

(3:58 - 4:21)

Interviewee: Because like, we're in Australia, but my accent definitely is in Australian. Uh, and then if it's kind of like I'm trying to introduce them the slang. So instead of saying things like, do you understand? So I'd say things like, oh, do you get it? Right? Yeah.

(4:23 - 5:34)

Interviewee: Um, I guess that and then if let's say we're stuck on a problem, we already have like a designated fail proof plan. So let's say, um, someone hasn't finished their work or anything else. But the one thing we can agree on is like, okay, let's go to class earlier.

Interviewee: So if all hell like breaks loose, and then like the communication isn't good or anything. I know for a fact that the point of getting a class on time cannot be mistaken. So if we get there on time, we start solving from there.

Interviewer: Yeah. Okay. So this is the question.

Interviewer: So do you ever feel responsible for carrying the communication load in the team? And is that fair in your view?

Interviewee: Um, in my case, it doubled down because I was one of the like, people with more software engineering experience. And I was the one who's more fluent in English. And I somehow had to step up to be the most extroverted member of the team because I know everyone's an introvert.

(5:35 - 6:51)

Interviewee: I feel like if we're talking objectively, no. But if we're talking subjectively, I feel like it is because I've been speaking in English for as long as I remember. But for them, they just got out of language school.

Interviewer: So not fair. Like, if I were to like, yeah, you know, yeah. Okay, so let's say if there was a shared device or robot in the room that could help translate or clarify things in real time during team conversations.

Interviewer: How do you think that will change the dynamic?

Interviewee: Um, so the dynamic would change from explaining it like ambilinguistic part and explaining on the technical part for my case. So now only being the technical parts of it. And I mean, with that device, I can talk how I normally talk.

Interviewee: Or I can even start talking in my native language, because for like coding and stuff, I'm used to working with other Indonesians. So it's either English or Indonesian. And in certain cases, as fluent as I am, I speak better Indonesian.

(6:52 - 7:48)

Interviewer: So that would be another advantage. Yeah. Okay.

Interviewer: Okay, last question. So what's one thing you wish you understood better about supporting a colleague with a language barrier?

Interviewee: Getting to know their mannerisms. Because communication isn't just the language that's spoken out.

Interviewee: It's the language that they act as well. So sometimes, you can try to see people who are willing to speak, but because of the language barrier, they become a bit more shy. But in some cases, they kind of just push through.

Interviewee: So I want to facilitate more of those who are like shy. So that way, yeah, with the use of the tool, we can get more things done. Like our conversations and our relationships will be better in the team dynamic.

(7:49 - 7:56)

Interviewer: Okay, so let's say if there was a robot that could do that, would you use it?

Interviewee: Oh, yeah, definitely.

Interviewer: Okay. Yeah.

(7:57 - 7:59)

Interviewer: Okay, that's all for the interview. Thank you so much.

(Transcribed by TurboScribe.)